both statistically significant and substantively meaningful: Moving from a nonpopulist- to a populist-led government corresponds to an approximately 80 percent increase in Grays filed annually.

To validate these findings, we conduct several robustness checks. We include region-fixed effects to account for potential regional clustering, perform sensitivity analysis in which we iteratively drop each country from the sample to ensure that no single observation drives the results, employ random effects models to test whether results hold under alternative assumptions about data structure, use the `PanelMatch` method from Imai, Kim, and Wang (2023), and show robustness to an alternate dependent variable using the average word count of Grays as a proxy for engagement intensity. Results remain consistent across all tests.

A potential alternative explanation is that populists use Grays to echo their public criticisms of the IMF in private. If this is true, Grays might serve as a platform for venting grievances rather than constructive engagement. To test this, we compare the sentiment of Grays filed by populist and nonpopulist governments. Word clouds (figure 6.3) reveal no major tonal differences, with both groups focusing on technical economic issues like debt, markets, and fiscal policy. For a more systematic approach, we perform sentiment analysis using the Loughran and McDonald financial sentiment dictionary (Loughran and McDonald 2011), tailored to economic and financial topics.

The results confirm that Grays from populist and nonpopulist governments have similar sentiment scores. A simple difference-in-means test yields no statistically significant difference ($p = 0.874$), and regression analysis (table 6.3) corroborates this finding. These results indicate that populists' private IMF engagement is substantive rather than merely critical.

Our analysis demonstrates that populist-led governments participate in the IMF more heavily through private channels than their nonpopulist counterparts. This aligns with our theory that populists avoid overt engagement because of possible domestic political costs but still recognize the benefits of IMF cooperation. These findings underscore the dual strategy of public antagonism paired with private collaboration that populists often employ.